

St. Joseph's Anglo-Chinese School

F.5 English Language

Grammar - Lesson 2: Inversions

Inversions

Part 1: Proofreading quiz

Each sentence contains ONE error. Underline the error and write the full corrected sentence. Items 1–5 review relative clauses from Lesson 1; Item 6 previews today's topic — inversions.

Sentence	Correction (Teacher's version)
Social media connects people instantly which makes the world feel smaller.	Social media connects people instantly, which makes the world feel smaller. (Add a comma before the connective clause.)
Online courses are ideal for busy adults, especially those which have little time to attend classes.	Online courses are ideal for busy adults, especially those who have little time to attend classes. (People take 'who', not 'which'.)
There are dozens of messaging apps, all of them are free to use.	There are dozens of messaging apps, all of which are free to use. (A pronoun cannot join two clauses; use 'which'.)
The forum which students share their homework is very popular.	Teacher's Answer A: The forum on which students share their homework is very popular. Teacher's Answer B: The forum where students share their homework is very popular. (Add the missing preposition 'on'.)
Many teenagers spend hours gaming, that worries their parents.	Many teenagers spend hours gaming, which worries their parents. ('That' cannot begin a connective clause.)
Not only the internet connects people around the world, but it also spreads information quickly.	Not only does the internet connect people around the world, but it also spreads information quickly. (Move the auxiliary before the subject after 'Not only' — more on this today.)

Part 2: Two patterns for formal writing

Both patterns follow the same rule: the auxiliary verb (or the verb 'be') moves before the subject. We focus on two patterns that are high-value and safe for formal writing; two more advanced patterns are kept in the teacher's note at the end of this part.

Pattern 1: Not only ... but also ...

Structure:	Not only + auxiliary + subject + verb, but (subject) also + verb
Use in formal writing:	Adds a second advantage in proposals, reports and articles.
Example:	Not only does the scheme save money, but it also builds confidence.
Introducing a school e-learning platform would bring clear benefits. Not only does the platform give students round-the-clock access to learning materials, but it also allows teachers to track progress more closely. With such a system, revision becomes a habit rather than a scramble before exams.	

Pattern 2: Never / Rarely / Seldom

Structure:	Never / Rarely / Seldom + auxiliary + subject + verb
Use in formal writing:	Turns a criticism or a surprising claim into a formal, striking opening.
Example:	Rarely do we question our daily screen habits.
Many parents blame video games for every poor result. Rarely do they stop to consider how limited their children's other entertainment options are. The real problem may be the lack of balance, not the games themselves.	

Additional patterns (teacher's note — optional)

Introduce these two only after the class is secure with Patterns 1 and 2. The mechanism is the same: front the expression, then place the auxiliary before the subject.

Only + adverbial (only when / only after / only by)

Structure:	Only + when / after / by + clause or phrase + auxiliary + subject + verb
Example:	Only by issuing clear guidelines can schools protect students' privacy.

Trap: 'Only + noun' does NOT invert. 'Only students can join' is already correct; inversion happens only when 'only' is followed by an adverbial.

So ... that / Such ... that

Structure:	So + adjective + auxiliary + subject + verb + that ... OR Such + be + noun
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	phrase + that ...
Example:	So popular is online shopping that it has changed the way we buy things.

Use it to open with a strong statement when emphasising the scale or importance of an issue.

Part 3: Practice sets

Rewrite each simple sentence using the pattern given in the prompt. The sentences are all about technology and communication, so keep the register formal.

Example Set 1 (Not only ... but also ...)

Simple sentence:	The online platform saves paper, and it gives students instant feedback.
Prompt:	<i>Begin with 'Not only' to add a second advantage.</i>
Teacher's Answer:	Not only does the online platform save paper, but it also gives students instant feedback.

Example Set 2 (Not only ... but also ...)

Simple sentence:	E-books are cheaper than printed textbooks, and they are far lighter to carry.
Prompt:	<i>Use 'Not only ... but also ...' to combine the two advantages of e-books.</i>
Teacher's Answer:	Not only are e-books cheaper than printed textbooks, but they are also far lighter to carry.

Example Set 3 (Never / Rarely / Seldom)

Simple sentence:	People rarely question the amount of time they spend scrolling on their phones.
Prompt:	<i>Begin with 'Rarely'.</i>
Teacher's Answer:	Rarely do people question the amount of time they spend scrolling on their phones.

Example Set 4 (Never / Rarely / Seldom)

Simple sentence:	The workplace has never relied so heavily on technology.
Prompt:	<i>Begin with 'Never'.</i>
Teacher's Answer:	Never has the workplace relied so heavily on technology.

Example Set 5 (Only by ...)

Simple sentence:	Schools can protect students' privacy by issuing clear guidelines on social
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	media use.
Prompt:	<i>Begin with 'Only by'.</i>
Teacher's Answer:	Only by issuing clear guidelines on social media use can schools protect students' privacy.

Example Set 6 (Only by ...)

Simple sentence:	Bookshops can survive in the digital age by offering experiences that apps cannot match.
Prompt:	<i>Begin with 'Only by'.</i>
Teacher's Answer:	Only by offering experiences that apps cannot match can bookshops survive in the digital age.

Example Set 7 (So ... that)

Simple sentence:	The problem of cyberbullying is so serious that every school must act.
Prompt:	<i>Begin with 'So serious'.</i>
Teacher's Answer:	So serious is the problem of cyberbullying that every school must act.

Example Set 8 (So ... that)

Simple sentence:	Online shopping is so popular that it has changed how we buy things.
Prompt:	<i>Begin with 'So popular'.</i>
Teacher's Answer:	So popular is online shopping that it has changed how we buy things.

Part 4: Writing Task

Instructions:

Social media plays a big part in students' lives. Write ONE paragraph (about 80–100 words) giving your view on whether students should limit their use of social media. Use at least two inversions and one relative clause. **Remember: the flow of ideas comes first — never force in an inversion just for the sake of using one.**

Many people accuse social media of destroying students' concentration and turning them into passive consumers of short videos. Rarely do they mention the benefits it brings to learning, such as instant access to discussion groups and subject resources, which older generations could never enjoy. Not only does social media connect students with their classmates, but it also links them to news and ideas from around the world. Only by teaching young people to manage their digital habits, therefore, can schools turn these platforms from a distraction into a real learning tool.

Teacher's note — flow before form: every inversion in the model earns its place. 'Rarely' contrasts with the accusation in sentence 1; 'Not only ... but also ...' adds the second advantage; 'Only by ...' delivers the concluding recommendation (condition → result). The task asks for two inversions; the model uses three, but only because the flow stays natural. Ask students to read their paragraphs aloud: if an inversion makes the flow awkward, they should re-order the ideas instead of forcing the structure.